

Kenya court halts opening of US Ebola quarantine facility in the country

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The 50-bed isolation centre is to be staffed by US medics and was due to begin operations on Friday, according to an American official. The Kenyan government has not directly commented on the plan.

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A High Court judge barred the operation of any Ebola facility in Kenya by any foreign government until the case is heard.

The exact location for the US treatment centre was not disclosed by the American authorities, but lawmakers from Laikipia county, central Kenya, have raised objections after reports emerged that it would be established in their area.

MPs called on the government to be clear about the details, saying they saw "no logic" in Kenya or Laikipia hosting the medical facility.

The US isolation centre is intended to treat US citizens believed to have been exposed to the virus in the Democratic Republic of Congo and Uganda, according to US officials.

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David Bhimji Atallah, KMPDU's secretary general, said the union "will not sit back and watch Kenya be treated as a containment colony for a lethal pathogen that we did not generate."

The union also objected to reports suggesting that the facility could be staffed by the US officials instead of Kenyan healthcare professionals.

"We will not tolerate an apartheid healthcare model on Kenyan soil," KMPDU warned.

The medical group gave the Kenyan government a 48-hour ultimatum to disclose details of the negotiations or risk nationwide industrial action.

"Kenya is a sovereign republic, not a geopolitical isolation ward," it added.

But in a statement after meeting foreign diplomats in Nairobi on Thursday, Kenya's President William Ruto said: "We agreed on the importance of cooperation and avoiding isolationism, recognising that public health threats do not respect borders and require coordinated regional and global action.

"Kenya will continue to act transparently, responsibly, and decisively to protect lives while contributing to regional and global health security," Ruto added.

He did not, however, directly refer to the US plans to establish the Ebola treatment centre.

US Secretary of State Marco Rubio also spoke with Ruto on the telephone on Thursday, Rubio's spokesperson said in a statement, adding that Washington intends to provide \$13.5m (£10.7 m) in aid to fund Kenya's Ebola preparedness efforts.

The amount is part of a larger \$112m US commitment for the regional response to the outbreak.

